

12, Why the Feudalization Process in China Abruptly Accelerated During the Han Dynasty

However, after China experienced the combined 70-year rule of Emperor Wu (汉武帝) and Huo Guang (霍光), its historical progression accelerated phenomenally, and certain measures implemented then later proved to be absolutely decisive.

In fact, much like the scenario in Japan, although relatively long periods are broadly classified as **classical empires** (古典帝国), we must look at the true essence of class transition. If we strictly define the "most typical" **classical society** (古典社会) as the specific epoch where the supreme ruler promotes and demotes officials "unconventionally" from all social classes and strata—ignoring explicit regulations or tacit rules, violently enforcing personal will, and filling the imperial bureaucracy with factions of divergent identities, ideologies, and demands to consolidate monarchical power—**then this specific historical stage in China was actually remarkably brief.**

It essentially lasted merely half a century under Emperor Wu's reign, which is even shorter than Japan's *Insei* (院政 / Cloistered Rule) period. (*Huo Guang, as a regent, inherently lacked the absolute conditions to arbitrarily appoint officials like a classical monarch; moreover, the prominent officials during his regency had mostly already emerged during Emperor Wu's reign.*)

Prior to this, imperial officials were overwhelmingly the descendants of meritorious ministers (功臣之后). After this, regardless of whether they acquired office through hereditary privilege (恩荫) or selection, officials were fundamentally of **bureaucratized landlord** (官僚化地主) origins. (*Of course, this could not be absolute; Emperor Xuan of Han would also heavily rely on friends from his commoner days, such as Dai Changle [戴长乐]. Yet, even Eastern Han scholars themselves conceded that "the Han's acquisition of talent reaching its zenith" strictly applied only to Emperor Wu's reign.*) By the Eastern Han Dynasty, the monopolization of power by the **aristocratic great clans** (门阀士族) became glaringly conspicuous, and officials from humble origins (寒门) were exceedingly rare.

It was precisely amidst such violent mutations that certain essential characteristics dictating the bureaucratic system of the Chinese Empire emerged, ultimately culminating in the restoration of a **bureaucratic state** (官僚国家). Considering the astonishing scale of military conquests during Emperor Wu's reign, **it is no exaggeration whatsoever to assert that China's bureaucratic system initially originated as a "wartime system" (战时体制).**

From the mid-Eastern Han Dynasty onwards, the **manorial economy** (庄园经济) seized the lion's share of the national economy, and the contraction of currency circulation became glaringly obvious. During the warlord chaos at the end of the Eastern Han, the **feudal** consciousness exhibited by various separatist factions was already exceptionally pronounced, and this phenomenon was entirely nationwide. At this point, a mere three centuries had elapsed since the death of Emperor Wu.

Conversely, counting 300 years forward from Rome's zenith, the Western Roman Empire had not yet officially collapsed, while the Eastern Roman Empire survived tenaciously, and its degree of **feudalization** (封建化) remained relatively low.

*(Although people routinely compare the Southern Dynasties following the "Crossing of the River by the Gentry" [衣冠南渡] to the Eastern Roman Empire, the two were fundamentally different in nature. When the Eastern Roman Empire was established, it was in a nascent state of **feudalization**. However, what transpired in the Eastern Jin, Song, Qi, Liang, and Chen dynasties was fundamentally no different from the North; it was merely another form of re-bureaucratization [再官僚化].*

*In fact, anyone familiar with the history of our Three Kingdoms period would easily realize that the Eastern Wu [东吴] regime was highly likely the most **feudalized** among the three separatist states. This is glaringly evident from Eastern Wu's military system [e.g., the Buqu / 世兵部曲制]. Logically, this is exceptionally coherent: the massive development of the southern regions during the Han Dynasties basically occurred after the bureaucratic system had matured under Emperor Wu. The **landlord class**, having rapidly infiltrated the state apparatus, spearheaded the development of the South. Coupled with the reality that "Heaven is high and the Emperor is far away" [天高皇帝远], it is not the least bit surprising that **feudalization** developed so rapidly there.)*

Therefore, we can deduce several core reasons why China's **feudalization** proceeded at such breakneck speed from the mid-Western Han to the late Eastern Han periods.

First, although the primary foreign trade corridors of China had been fully pioneered during Emperor Wu's reign, China's location at the extreme eastern terminus of the Eurasian landmass dictated that its international trade fundamentally could not be as hyper-developed as that of the Near East. Relative to China's own colossal economic mass, this trade volume was even more negligible.

It is international economic activity—not domestic economic activity—that serves as the crucial factor counteracting *feudalization*. This is because domestic economic activity will inherently contract as **feudalization** progresses, and the central government's control over the domestic economy will proportionally decay. Conversely, international trade concentrates at a few specific nodes, making it phenomenally easier for the imperial court to extract lucrative profits. The microscopically small proportion of international trade within the overall economy meant that China's **feudalization** process possessed absolutely zero buffer space.

Second, although from a holistic perspective, there was no era where China secured a commanding global lead in overall science and technology, **during the Han Dynasty—specifically the two centuries spanning the 1st century BC and the 1st century AD—the advancements achieved in iron and steel metallurgy were breathtakingly staggering.**

The puddling process (炒钢法), the co-fusion steelmaking process (灌钢法), the utilization of coal, hydraulic blast bellows (水力鼓风机 / *shuipai*), and blast furnaces (高炉炼铁) emerged in a concentrated burst. China instantaneously forged a massive, unbridgeable chasm in both the quality and output of iron and steel compared to the rest of the world. Initially, this was highly likely the result of centralized state management over metallurgy driven by military and economic imperatives; it cannot be ruled out that the Han government injected colossal capital investments into this sector.

The widespread popularization of iron tools potently elevated productive forces. Moreover, the Han Empire—particularly under Emperor Wu—relentlessly prioritized leveraging state power to popularize new agricultural techniques. Within merely a century following Emperor Wu's death,

China's population nearly doubled. Regardless of how much China lagged behind the Mediterranean world in engineering, mathematics, and philosophy, **it undeniably and abruptly seized a commanding lead in agricultural productive forces**. Consequently, the rapid consolidation of **feudal relations of production** (封建生产关系) was not the least bit surprising.

Third, the reform of the bureaucratic system massively facilitated the integration of the **landlord class** (地主阶级) into state politics, empowering them to rapidly amass wealth.

As for Emperor Wu himself, although he holistically favored cultivating rich peasant-landlords and developing **feudal** relations of production, his ultimate objective was to expropriate maximum revenue, grain, and manpower for his wars. When establishing the Regional Inspectors (刺史), the *Six Articles of Inspecting Commanderies* (六条察郡之法) he executed ruthlessly struck at local magnates (豪强) annexing land and local officials colluding with them. He also deliberately implemented the "law of geographical avoidance" (籍贯回避制度). This explicitly indicates that Emperor Wu personally recognized that **feudalization** would initially severely cripple state capacity.

However, all of this proved ultimately futile. Just as Emperor Wu firmly monopolized supreme decision-making power through the "Inner Court" (内朝)—while extensively recruiting talent from all echelons of society—this Inner Court, operating as a continuation of the classical imperial court, vanished swiftly after Huo Guang's death. Once a bureaucratic system was established that overwhelmingly advantaged the **landlord class** in monopolizing state power (as a distinct class), it was entirely inevitable that the **landlord class** would parasitize this system to reap profits for themselves. Let alone the reality that it was impossible for every subsequent emperor to possess the boundless energy and razor-sharp intellect of Emperor Wu.

Fourth, following Emperor Wu's reign, the Chinese Empire established absolute supremacy in this relatively isolated world of East Asia (*which also includes Northern Asia and portions of Southeast Asia; Xinjiang is included in East Asia as it is part of our nation's territory*). The empire had expanded to its absolute physical limits; there existed zero foreign powers capable of posing an existential challenge to the empire, and the Han people grew thoroughly accustomed to this hegemony.

Domestically, large-scale tribes, **communities** (社群), and **"internal frontiers"** only survived in the recently pacified South (*of course, "recently" is relative to the Yellow River basin, the mainstream core of Chinese civilization*); however, they had vanished entirely from the empire's core ruling zones. Furthermore, ethnic groups like the Baiyue (百越) and Baipu (百濮) were simply too overwhelmingly weak compared to the coalescing Han ethnicity. Meanwhile, the ethnic minorities operating along the northern frontiers spent two entire centuries trembling in terror under the overwhelming martial superiority of the Han Dynasty.

All these factors dictated that during the 1st century BC, and the 1st and 2nd centuries AD, the geopolitical reality confronting the Chinese Empire was actually exceedingly singular. (*Of course, in a sense, it wasn't inherently singular; it only became extraordinarily singular because Emperor Wu had annihilated and crushed an excessively massive multitude of enemies*). **Under these conditions, within the isolated world China inhabited, there existed absolutely zero external forces capable of obstructing China's feudalization process.**

12，中国的封建化进程为什么在汉代陡然加快

然而，中国在经历了武帝和霍光总共 70 年的执政之后，历史进程变得飞快，一些措施在日后被证明是决定性的。实际上，就跟日本发生的情况相同，尽管一些比较长的时期都被算为古典帝国，但是如果我们把最高统治者“不拘一格地”从社会各个阶级各个阶层，不按明确的规章或者默认规则而是依据个人意志强行黜陟官员，朝廷的官僚系统中充满不同身份，不同意识形态，不同诉求的团体并在这个过程中强化君主权力视为“最典型的”古典社会，也就是反映阶级过渡实质的古典社会，那么中国的这个历史阶段其实相当短暂，无非是汉武帝统治中国的半个世纪出头，这甚至比日本的院政还要短暂（霍光摄政时的重要官员大多在武帝时期就已经崭露头角，他作为摄政者像古典君主一样任意用人的条件毕竟不充足）。在此之前，朝廷官员多功臣之后；在此之后，官员无论是恩荫还是选拔基本是官僚地主出身，（当然这不可能是绝对的，汉宣帝也会重用自己在民间时的朋友，如戴长乐。只不过即使是东汉人自己都承认只有在武帝时可谓“汉之得人，于兹为盛”）在东汉门阀士族的垄断更为明显，寒门出身的官员极其稀少。

就是在这样剧烈的变化中，决定中华帝国官僚制度的一些本质特征出现了，并最终导致了官僚国家的复辟，考虑到汉武帝执政时期规模惊人的军事征服，说中国的官僚制度最初是一种战时体制一点都不为过。从东汉中期开始，庄园经济占据了国家经济的大头，货币流通萎缩已经十分明显。在东汉末年的军阀混战中，各割据势力所表现出的封建意识就已经十分明显了，而且是全国性的，这个时候距离汉武帝去世也只有三个世纪。而从罗马的鼎盛年代向后数 300 年，西罗马帝国还没有正式灭亡，而东罗马帝国还顽强地生存着，它的封建化程度还比较低。（虽然人们日常将衣冠南渡之后的南朝与东罗马帝国相比，但其实这两者具有本质上的不同。东罗马帝国在成立的时候处于一种将封建化的状态，但是东晋、宋、齐、梁、陈发生的事情跟北方并没有本质区别，是另一种形式的再官僚化。实际上只要熟悉我国三国时期的历史，就不难意识到东吴政权很有可能是三个割据国家中封建化程度最高的，这一点从东吴兵制就体现得很明显。而在逻辑上也十分通顺，两汉南方地区的大规模开发基本上是汉武帝执政时期官僚系统成熟之后的事，迅速进入国家政权的地主阶级主导了南方的开发。再加上天高皇帝远，封建化得以迅速发展就一点都不奇怪了。）因此我们可以总结出中国从西汉中期至东汉末期封建化迅速进行有以下几个原因。

第一，虽然汉武帝时期中国主要的对外贸易通道就已经完成开拓，但是作为欧亚大陆的东端经过中国的国际贸易毕竟不可能像近东地区这么发达，相对于中国自身庞大的体量来说就更微弱。国际间经济活动而非国内经济活动才是抵消封建化的重要因素，因为国内经济活动本身会随着封建化消退，而中央政府对于国内经济活动的控制也会削弱。相反国际贸易集中在少数几个地点，朝廷更容易从中获利。国际贸易占经济比重过小导致中国的封建化进程没有任何缓冲的余地。

第二，虽然从整体上看，中国在科学技术方面没有哪个时期能取得遥遥领先世界。但是在汉代，特别是公元前一世纪和公元一世纪二百年间，钢铁冶炼技术取得的进步过于惊人了，炒钢法、灌钢法、煤炭使用、水力鼓风机和高炉炼铁集中出现。中国在钢铁的质量和产量上与世界其他地区迅速拉开了巨大差距，这在最初可能是出于军事和经济目的对于钢铁冶炼进行集中管理的成果，不排除汉朝政府追加了大量投资。铁制工具的广泛普及有力地提高了生产力，而且汉帝国特别是汉武帝时期非常注重用国家力量普及新的耕作方法。在汉武帝去世之后的一个世纪里，中国的人口增长了近一倍。不管在工程学，数学，哲学这些方面中国比起地中海世界落后多少，但是在农业生产力上确实骤然就取得了显著的领先地位，封建生产关系的快速确立就毫不奇怪。

第三，官僚制度的改革有利于地主阶级参与国家政治当中，使得他们能够迅速扩大自己的财富。就汉武帝本人而言他虽然在整体上倾向于扶植富农地主，发展封建生产关系，不过他本人的目的最终还是为战争筹措最多的钱粮兵马。在汉武帝设立刺史时所执行的《六条察郡之法》严厉打击豪强兼并土地以及地

方官吏阿附豪强，并有意识地采取籍贯回避制度，这其实表明武帝本人对于封建化在最初会削弱国家能力是有认识的。不过并没有什么用，就好比汉武帝本人统治时期依然通过内朝牢牢控制着最高决定权，并且从社会各界广纳网罗人才，然而内朝作为古典宫廷的延续在霍光死之后就很快消失了一样。既然有了一套有利于地主阶级单独（作为阶级）掌握国家权力的官僚制度，地主阶级利用这套制度为自己谋利就是完全免不了的，更不要说不可能每个皇帝都跟武帝一样精力充沛，思维敏锐。

第四，自武帝之后，中华帝国在东亚（也包括北亚和东南亚的一部分，新疆因为是我国领土所以算为东亚地区）这个相对隔绝的世界建立起了绝对的优势，扩张到极限，已经不存在任何外国势力能够对帝国构成挑战，汉人也习惯这个局面。在国内，大范围的部族、社群和内部边疆仅仅存在于平定不久的南方（当然不久是对于中华文明主流产生的黄河流域来说），但是帝国的核心统治区已经没有它们的踪影了，而且百越、百濮等民族相对于形成中的汉族而言实在是弱得过分。在北方边境活动的少数民族已经在汉朝的优势武力下战战兢兢地度过了三个世纪。这些因素都意味着在公元前一世纪，一世纪和二世纪，中华帝国所面临的情况实际上非常单一。当然某种程度上说其实也没这么单一，只不过因为自汉武帝开始消灭和打击的敌人实在过多，因此最后形成局面十分单一。在这种情况下，中国所处的世界中没有任何外部力量能够阻挠中国的封建化进程。